

Game Design Principles One Pager

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Summary

This one-pager briefly describes three game design principles and the ways some example games make use of them.

One of my favorite game design principles in story-based games is to embed the player's long-term goals, not just the short-term goals, into the level design. Skyrim, Half-Life 2, and Deadcore do this by literally having the end-goal as a part of the skybox.

Another game design principle I love is building around emergent gameplay, allowing the players to invent their own solutions to the game's problems. Minecraft is one of the most well-known examples of emergent gameplay, but this principle is a part of many less obvious games like Distance or Portal where the player is given a tool and encouraged to find the loopholes in the game's design.

Finally, I really prefer games that teach game-play mechanics without making them explicitly taught to the player. This plays into my love of emergent gameplay, but this specifically describes allowing the player to find mechanics based on the level's circumstances instead of explicitly describing the mechanics to them. Fract OSC would be a great example of this, because in order to teach you mechanics, it just has a smaller level at the start of the game where each mechanic is required in order to progress but without explicitly stating those mechanics to you.

One of the upsides of embedding long-term goals into level design is that it gives the player a sense of the long-term purpose of the player's actions within the game and constantly reminds the player of the long-term goals they are working towards.¹ This can give both direction to the player and extra motivation to keep coming back to the game until the very visible long-term goals are accomplished. However, this game design principle only works well in games where the long-term goal is a part of the game's gameplay instead of being simply a meta-goal like completing all the levels or raising your player rank.

The reason building around emergent gameplay might be a good idea is that it gives players the opportunity to be creative and figure out how to achieve goals on their own. Furthermore, it allows the developers to simply focus on the mechanics of the game, making sure they work well together without having to provide every part of the player's experience. However this can be undesirable in especially story-driven games where deviating from the storyline can cause strange, immersion breaking, interactions and glitches.

One of the pros of teaching without teaching is that it can allow the game to be more immersive without having to break immersion to explain a mechanic to the player. Furthermore, allowing players to discover mechanics on their own can add to a sense of achievement. However, if some mechanics are necessary to play the game but are not immediately obvious, such as which buttons move the player, it can be better to explicitly explain these mechanics to the player.

¹ <https://gamedevacademy.org/game-design-principles-tutorial/>

In my own game, I do not intend to have much of a focus on story if any. This means that depicting long-term goals within the level design would not make much sense in many scenarios. However, I am considering having a team-based multiplayer mode in the game where I might be able to apply this longer-term goal in level design principle. The way I could apply it might be to make all teams' bases clearly visible from everywhere in the map.

I most definitely intend for my game to focus on emergent gameplay, as I find this as one of the most interesting game design pillars, both as a developer and as a player. I intend on letting players develop their own strategies and complete level objectives in creative ways that I likely would not even think of. The only time I might discourage a specific style of emergent gameplay would be if I found it boring. An example of boring emergent mechanics would be how in Distance you can often flip your car over and use the car's guidance thrusters to fly straight to the end of the level.

Finally, I intend on teaching as many of my game's mechanics as I can without actually explicitly teaching them. My goal is to make my game fun, both to play, and to learn. However, there will likely be some mechanics that I will have to explicitly teach, such as basic movement and how to complete a level. In general though, with my game's focus on emergent mechanics, I intend for players to discover and develop those gameplay styles themselves.

AI Usage: N/A